

Physical Assessment

Question 1

A patient presents with shortness of breath after surgery. The nurse checks lung sounds, oxygen saturation, and breathing pattern. This BEST describes what type of assessment?

- a. Emergency assessment
- b. Ongoing/partial assessment
- c. Comprehensive initial assessment
- d. Focused/problem-oriented assessment

Correct answer: d. Focused/problem-oriented assessment

Rationale:

The nurse is assessing specific systems (respiratory) related to a current problem (post-operative shortness of breath), not the whole body. This defines a focused assessment.

Question 2

Analysis of a client's report of "pitting and crumbling nails" would lead the nurse to consider which set of potential causes?

- a. Hormonal changes that can occur during periods such as puberty.

- b. Nutritional deficiencies, systemic diseases, or localized fungal infections.
- c. Emotional stress that may contribute to habitual nail-biting behaviors.
- d. Arterial insufficiency with reduced circulation to the extremities.

Correct answer: b. Nutritional deficiencies, systemic diseases, or localized fungal infections

Rationale:

Pitting and crumbling nails are classic signs of iron deficiency, fungal infection, or systemic illness, not emotional or hormonal causes.

Question 3

Which abdominal quadrant should the nurse begin auscultation in?

- a. Right Upper Quadrant (RUQ)
- b. Right Lower Quadrant (RLQ)
- c. Left Lower Quadrant (LLQ)
- d. Left Upper Quadrant (LUQ)

Correct answer: b. Right Lower Quadrant (RLQ)

Rationale:

Auscultation starts in the RLQ because bowel sounds are normally most active there (ileocecal valve area).

Question 4

A barrel chest, characterized by an increased anteroposterior (AP) diameter, is MOST commonly associated with which condition?

- a. Chronic Obstructive Pulmonary Disease (COPD)
- b. Pneumothorax with deviated trachea
- c. Lobar pneumonia with foul smelling sputum
- e. Scoliosis found in female patients

Correct answer: a. Chronic Obstructive Pulmonary Disease (COPD)

Rationale:

Barrel chest results from air trapping and hyperinflation, commonly seen in COPD/emphysema.

Question 5

Foul-smelling sputum is typically associated with which of the following?

- a. Lung abscess or bacterial infection
- b. Pulmonary embolism

c. Simple bronchospasm

d. Viral tracheal infection

Correct answer: a. Lung abscess or bacterial infection

Rationale:

Foul-smelling sputum indicates anaerobic bacterial infection or lung abscess.

Question 6

A patient reports waking up 1-2 hours after falling asleep with severe shortness of breath and a need to go

To the window for air. The nurse interprets this as:

a. Paroxysmal Nocturnal Dyspnea

b. Orthopnea

c. Tachycardia

d. Dyspnea on exertion

Correct answer: a. Paroxysmal Nocturnal Dyspnea

Rationale:

PND causes sudden breathlessness after falling asleep, forcing the patient to sit or seek air.

Question 7

During a physical assessment, a nurse finds a palpable mass in the patient's right anterior chest at the 5th rib in the mid-clavicular line. Based on lung anatomy, which lobe is MOST likely being assessed?

- a. Right lower lobe
- b. Right medial lobe
- c. Right upper lobe
- d. Right middle lobe

Correct answer: d. Right middle lobe

Rationale:

The 5th intercostal space at the mid-clavicular line corresponds to the right middle lobe.

Question 8

What is the recommended frequency for a fecal occult blood test for men over 50?

- a. Every year
- b. Every month

c. Every 10 years

d. Every 5 years

Correct answer: a. Every year

Rationale:

Fecal occult blood testing is recommended annually for men over 50 for colorectal cancer screening.

Question 9

A client reports epigastric pain that is dull and general. The nurse understands that this type of pain is MOST likely:

a. Visceral pain

b. Somatic pain

c. Parietal pain

d. Referred pain

Correct answer: a. Visceral pain

Rationale:

Visceral pain is dull, poorly localized, and arises from internal organs.

Question 10

The primary purpose of the initial comprehensive assessment is to:

- a. Perform immediate life-saving interventions only
- b. Detect only abnormalities associated with chief complaints
- c. Establish baseline data for future comparison
- d. Assess medication effectiveness after admission

Correct answer: c. Establish baseline data for future comparison

Rationale:

The initial comprehensive assessment provides baseline data to track changes over time.

Question 11

While assessing a patient's posterior chest, the nurse palpates for tactile fremitus and finds it is significantly decreased over the left lower lobe. The nurse should suspect which of the following

Conditions?

- a. Lobar pneumonia confined to the left lower lobe

- b. Pleural effusion or pneumothorax on the left
- c. Acute bronchitis involving the central airwaysd. Consolidation that is localized to the left upper lobe

Correct answer: b. Pleural effusion or pneumothorax on the left

Rationale:

Both conditions decrease tactile fremitus by preventing vibration transmission.

Question 12

A patient with kyphoscoliosis is at risk for which of the following respiratory complications?

- a. Increased lung capacity due to chest wall remodeling.
- b. Chronic hyper-resonance due to air trapping.
- c. Unilateral tracheal deviation away from the curvature.
- d. Restricted lung capacity due to structural deformity.

Correct answer: d. Restricted lung capacity due to structural deformity

Rationale:

Kyphoscoliosis restricts chest expansion, leading to reduced lung volumes.

Question 13

A patient with a history of hypertension presents with a bounding carotid pulse. The nurse concludes that

This finding could be consistent with all the following conditions EXCEPT:

- a. Hyperthyroidism producing an amplified pulse wave
- b. Aortic regurgitation causing forceful carotid pulses
- c. Severe aortic stenosis reducing carotid pulse strength
- d. Fever increasing cardiac output and pulse volume

Correct answer: c. Severe aortic stenosis reducing carotid pulse strength

Rationale:

Bounding pulses occur with high stroke volume, not with aortic stenosis which weakens pulses.

Question 14

A diminished carotid pulse is a sign of decreased stroke volume. This can be seen in all the following

Conditions EXCEPT:

- a. Hypovolemic Shock
- b. Aortic Stenosis
- c. Heart Failure
- d. Severe Anemia

Correct answer: d. Severe Anemia

Rationale:

Severe anemia often causes bounding pulses, not diminished ones.

Question 15

The health history revealed that the patient requires many pillows for sleeping. Which of the following

Could be the patient's disorder?

- a. Orthopnea
- b. Peripheral Edema
- c. Tachycardia

d. Paroxysmal Nocturnal Dyspnea

Correct answer: a. Orthopnea

Rationale:

Needing multiple pillows to breathe comfortably indicates orthopnea.

Question 16

As the nurse performs a head-to-toe physical assessment, which finding BEST indicates that the client's

Ulcer has perforated? The client's:

- a. Skin is ecchymotic.
- b. Abdomen feels board-like.
- c. Pupils are widely dilated.
- d. Respirations are rapid.

Correct answer: b. Abdomen feels board-like

Rationale:

A rigid, board-like abdomen suggests perforated ulcer with peritonitis.

Question 17

The nurse is analyzing risk factors for colorectal cancer. Which client has the LEAST significant risk factor based on the information presented?

- a. A 50-year-old with a recent change in bowel pattern.
- b. A 60-year-old who has never had a sigmoidoscopy.
- c. A 45-year-old with occasional constipation related to diet.
- d. A 55-year-old with a family history of colon polyps.

Correct answer: c. A 45-year-old with occasional constipation related to diet

Rationale:

Diet-related constipation alone is not a significant colorectal cancer risk.

Question 18

A nurse questions the reliability of information from a confused patient. The MOST appropriate evaluation step is to:

- a. Base care solely on past medical records
- b. Seek collateral information from at least one secondary source
- c. Request a psychiatric assessment before continuing

- d. Stop history taking and perform only physical exam

Correct answer: b. Seek collateral information from at least one secondary source

Rationale:

When primary data is unreliable, secondary sources are essential.

Question 19

A purple discoloration at the flanks, known as Grey-Turner sign, indicates:

- a. Bleeding within the abdominal wall
- b. Pancreatic mass causing tissue injury
- c. Bleeding into the peritoneum
- d. Liver disease involving fluid shifts

Correct answer: c. Bleeding into the peritoneum

Rationale:

Grey-Turner sign indicates retroperitoneal bleeding, commonly pancreatitis.

Question 20

Which of the following statements BEST describes dead space?

- a. "It refers to passageways like the trachea where no gas exchange occurs."
- b. "It refers to the pleural space where infection can form an abscess."
- c. "This is the area in the alveoli where carbon dioxide builds up."
- d. "It's the space in the sinus cavities that can get blocked during a cold."

Correct answer: a. Passageways like the trachea where no gas exchange occurs

Rationale:

Dead space includes conducting airways with no gas exchange.

Question 21

A client states that a rash on their arms started after using a new laundry detergent. They report that it itches and is slightly raised. Which of the following conclusions by the nurse is BEST supported by this data? The rash is:

- a. Definitely contagious based on its superficial appearance.
- b. Caused by a nutritional deficiency affecting the skin.
- c. Likely a symptom of an underlying systemic illness.
- d. Likely related to an allergic response to the new product.